



OSAKA JAPAN

Okonomiyaki in Osaka

Osaka became a wealthy food-trading center in the 16th century, and has been famously serious about its food ever since. The third-largest city in Japan, it's also famously fast-paced, so it's not surprising that its inhabitants have become fast-food aficionados. Of all the city's superb snacklike creations, *okonomiyaki* is the favorite choice for food on the run.



Though it's not such an obvious choice for tourists as Tokyo, and not even the locals would ever claim it was pretty, Osaka is a dynamic, characterful city whose inhabitants are famed throughout the country for their sense of humor, their slightly contrary nature, and their gluttony (the local dialect even has a word for this: *kuidaore*, which means "eat till you bust").

Although Osaka doesn't tend to feature on tourist itineraries – it is rather overshadowed in this part of Japan by Kyoto and Nara – the city has put some effort into developing a few tourist attractions. It has Osaka-jo castle, a mostly re-created 16th-century residence, and a magnificent aquarium – which has one of the very few whale sharks in captivity in the world – as well as several excellent museums and the gigantic Universal Studios Japan fun park. The shopping is especially epic, with massive malls and the longest *shotengai* (covered shopping arcade) in Japan. More interestingly, in recent years travelers from around the world have slowly come to realize that thanks to the locals' famously insatiable appetites

and ceaseless curiosity about new things, Osakan cuisine is more open to innovation and foreign influence than other Japanese regional foods. As a result, this city has a great deal to offer foodies, particularly in the realm of fast food. This is the city that invented conveyor-belt sushi and instant noodles (both in 1958, curiously), but today Osaka's claim to fame lies in a triumvirate of unique fast foods: *tako yaki*, *kushikatsu* (see box, below left), and, most famously of all, *okonomiyaki*.

Literally meaning "make it how you like," *okonomiyaki* usually features shredded cabbage, green onion, and pork (or shrimp or squid), all mixed together with a batter made from flour, *dashi* (stock), eggs, and, crucially for that chewy moistness, grated yam. This is then poured onto a hotplate where it is fried, flipped, fried some more, slathered with thick, dark, tangy-sweet sauce, and sprinkled with various toppings, including *kimchi* (Korean pickled vegetables), nori, Japanese mayonnaise, and *katsuobushi* (dried bonito flakes), before being cut into slices and devoured. It's a sociable dish, popular date food, and the definitive "must-have" in Osaka.



Above In 1583, the founder of Osaka, Toyotomi Hideyoshi, built the original Osaka-jo castle on the site of the Ishiyama Honganji Temple, to act as the center of a new, unified Japan

What Else to Eat

Along with *okonomiyaki* and instant noodles, Osaka has given the world other great fast foods. **Kushikatsu** are breaded, deep-fried skewers of vegetables, seafood, and meat dipped in yet another addictive, meaty-sugary, ebony-colored sauce. **Tako yaki** are chunks of octopus cooked in a doughnut-like batter, slathered with brown sauce and *katsuobushi* flakes – classic Osakan street food. But perhaps the perfect symbol of the famed impatience of Osakans is *kaiten* or "conveyor-belt" sushi, which was invented in the city in the 1950s. Though the quality at a *kaiten* place is no match for a "proper" sushi restaurant, it does meet the average Osakan's main criterion for a meal – speed of delivery. In fact, it is said that the conveyor belts are set to move faster in Osaka than they do in Tokyo.

A Day in Osaka

Osaka is the capital of Osaka Prefecture, and its busy beating heart. You're as likely to come across fascinating sights and food while wandering the city as you are when visiting tourist sites, so don't underestimate the value of a walking tour.

MORNING If you can make the 5 AM start, the **Osaka Municipal Wholesale Market** is legendary, and rivals Tokyo's Tsukiji for diversity and quality. Breakfast on a hearty bowl of *oden* (a kind of Japanese stew) upstairs in the cafeterias, then spend the rest of the morning at the **Osaka Aquarium**. Have lunch on the run, perhaps freshly cooked *tako yaki* from a stand on **Dotonbori**, the famous food street where (unusually for Japan) sidewalk snacking is positively encouraged.

AFTERNOON Hit the shops of **Minami** (Osaka is divided into two main neighborhoods: Kita in the north, with the main station; and Minami in the south). Walk Japan's longest covered shopping street, the 1½-mile- (2.5-km-) long **Tenjinbashi-suji** arcade, or opt for the more upmarket **Shinsaibashi**.

EVENING Return to **Dotonbori**, the life and soul of Osaka's 24/7 food party, which blazes with neon. Look for the giant crab – and eat *okonomiyaki*, of course.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Osaka's **Kansai International Airport** is one of Japan's largest. The city has an extensive subway network as well as trams and buses.

WHERE TO STAY

The **Dotonbori Hotel** (inexpensive) offers large, modern rooms in the center of Dotonbori. www.dotonbori-h.co.jp

Dojima Hotel (moderate) is an uber-cool boutique hotel conveniently located between Kita and Minami. www.dojima-hotel.com

Imperial Hotel Osaka (expensive) is the sister hotel to the equally grand Imperial in Tokyo. Features include its own golf driving range. www.imperialhotel.co.jp

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.jnto.go.jp/eng